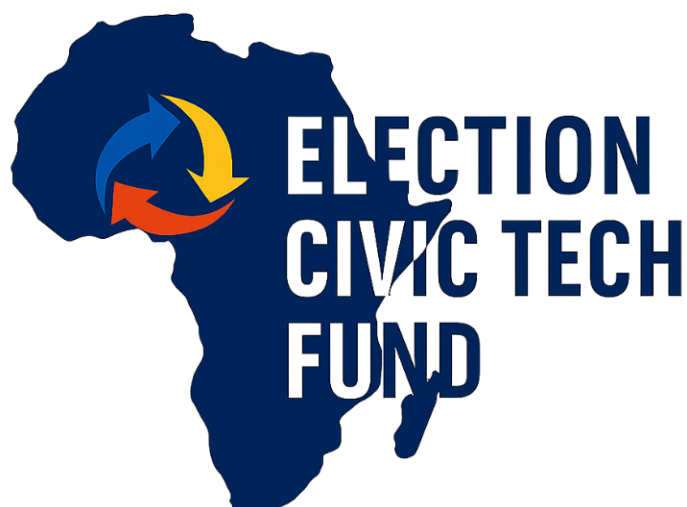


Concept Note

Innovation Fund for Citizen Participation in Electoral Processes in Africa ELECTION CIVIC TECH FUND

**

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June 2025

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I. I. Why the Election Civic Tech Fund?

In 2021, following the COVID-19 health crisis, AfricTivistes conducted a study on the strong involvement of young Africans in initiatives responding to the pandemic. This AfricTivistes Youth Initiatives Mapping (AYIM) [study](#), covering 10 French- and English-speaking Sub-Saharan African countries, revealed a lack of financial and technical support for citizen participation from donors and authorities at all levels (local, regional and national). Most of the initiatives identified were self-funded through contributions, personal efforts or informal mobilisation.

Few received external support, mostly from a limited number of NGOs or international agencies (e.g. Plan International, UNICEF, Heinrich Böll Stiftung, etc).

Francophone Africa:

- **48 initiatives** self-funded totalling **US\$ 1,227,877**
- **25 initiatives** externally funded totalling **US\$ 497,063**
- Notable example: **Côte d'Ivoire**, all initiatives were **autonomous**.

Anglophone Africa:

- **18 initiatives** self-funded: **US\$ 589,571**
- **16 initiatives** supported: **US\$ 228,984**

While some organisations received **occasional grants** (e.g. in Mauritania: **UNICEF** → US\$ 948, **Ministry of Youth** → US\$ 4,742), most were forced to limit their scope due to lack of resources.

In 2024, AfricTivistes conducted *Sóobu Tech4Elections*, a [mapping of electoral civic initiatives](#) under the [AHEAD Africa](#) project. Of 57 initiatives mapped, only 7 received direct financial support without additional technical or logistical aid. This again confirmed [AYIM's](#) 2021 findings.

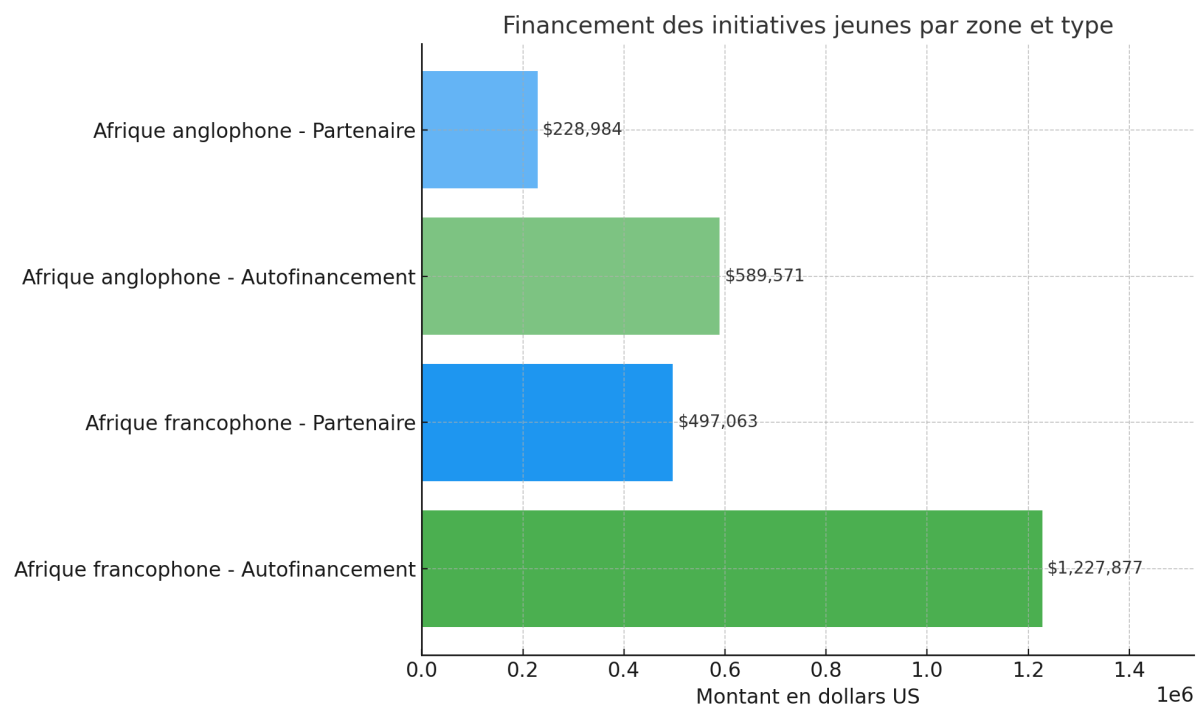
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Mapping African youth initiatives during the COVID-19 crisis [Télécharger la Cartographie](#)

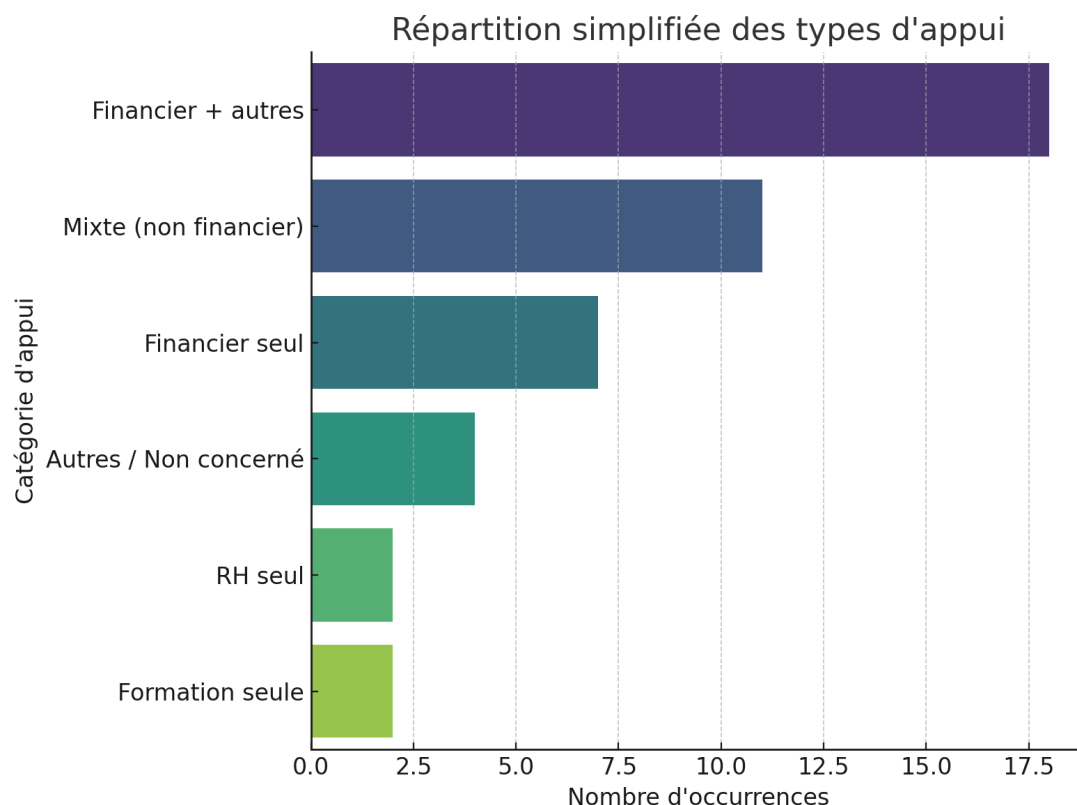
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Data on funding from the Soobu.tech mapping

- Financial only: Strictly financial support with no other support
- Mixed (non-financial): Several non-financial supports combined.
- Financial + other: Financial combined with logistical, technical, HR, etc.
- Technical only, Training only, HR only: Support targeted at a single non-financial area.
- Other / Not concerned: Ambiguous cases, unspecified or no support. Visit [Soobu](#)

In view of this, we have to recognise that civic initiatives - whether related to the response to the pandemic, to governance or to democracy - are cruelly lacking in structured and consistent support from donors and public institutions.

This lack of support is even more pronounced when it comes to civic tech applied to electoral processes. The structural lack of funding dedicated to electoral civic tech considerably limits the emergence, experimentation and sustainability of local solutions that are essential to the transparency and integrity of elections. Civil society players,

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although committed, are struggling to mobilise the resources needed to design, experiment with and disseminate digital tools tailored to electoral contexts.

To address this, AfricTivistes is launching the 'Election Civic Tech Fund', a dedicated financing mechanism to support digital innovations in the field of election observation and democratic advocacy. The fund aims to fill a strategic gap by supporting project initiators, fostering collaboration between players and catalysing technological solutions for more transparent, inclusive and resilient elections.

II. What is the Innovation Fund for Citizen Participation in Electoral Processes in Africa (Election Civic Tech Fund)?

According to the study [Electoral violence in sub-Saharan Africa: Causes and consequences](#), more than 50% of elections in sub-Saharan Africa since 1990 have been marked by electoral violence, ranging from intimidation to armed conflict. Most crises result from electoral processes, notably the 2007 crisis in Kenya, the 2010 civil war in Côte d'Ivoire and the 2011 electoral dispute in Nigeria. Recurring causes include weak electoral institutions, manipulation of results, ethnic tensions and a lack of trust in democratic processes.

Thus, the transparency and integrity of electoral processes in Africa remain major challenges, directly impacting democratic stability and citizens' trust in their public institutions. In the face of these challenges, civic technologies offer innovative solutions to strengthen electoral observation, improve accountability and encourage inclusive citizen participation.

AfricTivistes launches the *Innovation Fund for Citizen Participation in Electoral Processes in Africa: Election Civic Tech Fund*, a grant mechanism dedicated to innovative civic initiatives.

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The beneficiaries will be selected following calls for proposals open to youth in the 14 countries covered by the AHEAD Africa project and which are the priority countries of Digitalise Youth: **Somalia, Ethiopia, Sudan, South Sudan, Senegal, Benin, Burkina Faso, Guinea, Chad, Cameroon, Mauritania, Niger, Mali and Togo.**

III. Who manages the Election Civic Tech Fund?

AfricTivistes is a pan-African network working to promote democracy, good governance, transparency and the rule of law through the strategic use of information technologies. With its continental presence, AfricTivistes positions itself as a pioneer and key player in the African civic tech ecosystem, with recognised expertise in managing large-scale programmes and participatory and citizen-based funding mechanisms.

The organisation has demonstrated its capacity to lead multisectoral and transnational projects since its creation in 2015, including among others:

- [Local Open GovLab \(LOG\)](#) for open local governance by subsidising seven (7) young Africans to support local authorities in Senegal, Guinea, Guinea-Bissau and Niger.
- [ICT4Justice](#) to popularise the African Commission on Human and Peoples' Rights (ACHPR) by subsidising 10 organisations, movements and associations to organise local activities on human rights, highlighting the role and mechanisms of the ACHPR.
- [INNOV4Democracy](#) to support citizen digital innovation through the development, experimentation and scaling of digital solutions led by five young Africans to address governance, transparency and civic participation challenges.

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- [AfricTivistes Civic Action Prize \(ACAP\)](#) to highlight and value young people leading high-impact initiatives by funding the scale-up of their projects.
- [Femmes Cybersecurity](#) to promote increased inclusion of women in digital and civic spaces. AfricTivistes funded around twenty women to raise awareness, equip and train hundreds of others on digital hygiene, online security and especially on prevention techniques against cyber harassment.

Beyond funding, AfricTivistes has established a logic of recognition, reward and visibility for inspiring role models, in order to encourage civic engagement and amplify impact. Through distinctions such as:

- the [Anna Gueye Prize](#), which rewards professional journalists and civil society information actors who have distinguished themselves by their handling of information and civic commitment,
- the [Media and Democracy Prize](#), which rewards media outlets that contribute to promoting democracy, transparency and accountability through committed, ethical and public interest journalism,
- the [AfricTivistes Champion of Governance and Democracy](#), which identifies and honours political leaders and public figures who have helped strengthen the principles of the African Charter on Democracy in the course of their duties.

This positioning at the crossroads of financing, strategic support and the promotion of African models confirms AfricTivistes as the bearer of the **Election Civic Tech Fund**, an innovation fund for citizen participation in electoral processes in Africa. It is a continental approach that is inclusive, agile and geared towards real impact.

This Fund is implemented as part of the Digitalise Youth and AHEAD Africa projects in which AfricTivistes is involved. [Digitalise Youth](#) aims to strengthen digital democracy, youth participation and influence in democratic processes through digital means in the 14 target countries. [AHEAD Africa](#) aims to improve transparency, integrity and citizen participation in electoral processes through strategic and technical support to African civil society.

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The choice of countries is based on a thorough analysis of their political and democratic context. These countries present specific challenges in terms of governance, citizen participation and electoral transparency, making support for civic tech initiatives to strengthen democracy particularly relevant.

IV. What is the objective of the Election Civic Tech Fund?

Support, encourage and promote innovative initiatives that strengthen citizen participation, transparency and the integrity of electoral processes in Africa.

Specific objectives

- Encourage the emergence of civic tech
- Strengthen the participation of youth and women through technology
- Support the rise of new communities of actors committed to electoral transparency

V. What is the total budget of the Fund?

Le Fonds de l'innovation pour la participation citoyenne dans les processus électoraux en Afrique (Election Civic Tech Fund) est doté d'une enveloppe de 175 000 euros destinés à la subvention de projets qui seront sélectionnés pour financer la mise en œuvre de leurs activités et assurer un impact durable.

The Innovation Fund for Citizen Participation in Electoral Processes in Africa (Election Civic Tech Fund) has a total budget of **€175,000** allocated to funding selected projects to support the implementation of their activities and ensure lasting impact.

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Grant amounts will range from **€10,000 to €25,000**, depending on the specific needs of each beneficiary initiative.

VI. How to benefit from the Election Civic Tech Fund?

VI.1. Who can be a beneficiary?

The Innovation Fund for Citizen Participation in Electoral Processes in Africa is open to **young people aged 18 to 35**, of nationality and/or residing in one of the **14** target countries:

- Cameroon
- Benin
- Burkina Faso
- Ethiopia
- Guinea
- Mauritania
- Mali
- Niger
- Chad
- Senegal
- Somalia
- Sudan
- South Sudan
- Togo

More specifically, the Fund targets young people who are:

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- organised as a group, movement, association or startup legally registered;
- part of a consortium with an entity registered in one of the target countries;
- operating in the Fund's target countries;
- able to demonstrate their motivation to continue the project after the grant ends;
- capable of producing narrative and financial progress reports during implementation;
- leading initiatives aligned with the Fund's priority areas;
- proposing open-source solutions to promote openness and reusability;

Initiatives led by women that meet the eligibility criteria will be prioritised. Members of the Digitalise Youth and AHEAD Africa consortiums cannot be beneficiaries of the Fund. However, past or current beneficiaries of [Digitalise Youth](#) or [AHEAD Africa](#) projects are eligible to apply for a grant.

VI.2. What are the Fund's priority areas?

The priority areas of the Innovation Fund for Citizen Participation in Electoral Processes in Africa are as follows:

- **D.1 : Electoral civic technologies**

This area focuses on technological innovation applied to electoral processes. It includes:

- The use of advanced technologies such as blockchain and artificial intelligence
- The development of civic tech tools to stimulate electoral engagement
- Adaptation to local contexts through mobile technologies and local languages
- Strengthening digital security

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- **D.2 : Citizen engagement and electoral processes**

This strand aims to strengthen citizen participation in democratic processes. It covers:

- Programmes for civic, citizen and electoral education
- Citizen-led electoral observation initiatives
- Projects that promote inclusion and participation of youth and women

- **D.3 : Media and information**

This area focuses on the quality and integrity of electoral information. It includes:

- Fact-checking and the processing of electoral information
- Combatting disinformation and responding to foreign information manipulation and interference (FIMI)
- Developing innovative citizen media

- **D.4 : Legal framework**

This component concerns the legal and regulatory aspects of electoral processes. It includes:

- Support for electoral reforms
- Monitoring of electoral disputes
- Setting up legal monitoring mechanisms

Each proposed project **must integrate the use of digital technologies** in several aspects of its activities, as a central tool for innovation, citizen participation and social impact.

Applicants may submit a **cross-cutting project** covering all the priority areas listed above. However, **each applicant may submit only one proposal**.

Please refer to the **Terms of Reference** for further details on the priority areas.

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VI.3. How are projects evaluated?

The project evaluation criteria include:

- The relevance and innovation of the proposed technological solution
- The potential impact on citizen participation and electoral transparency
- The technical and financial feasibility of the project
- The potential for replication and scale-up of the proposal

A multidisciplinary selection committee comprising **eight (8) members**, including members of the consortium, will be established to identify the beneficiary projects.

VI.4. How is the Fund's budget allocated?

The total Fund amount of **€175,000** will be distributed across the different priority areas as follows:

- **40% (€70,000)** for Electoral Civic Technologies (D.1)
- **25% (€43,750)** for Citizen Engagement and Electoral Processes (D.2)
- **20% (€35,000)** for Media and Information (D.3)
- **15% (€26,250)** for the Legal Framework (D.4)

Between four (4) and six (6) major projects will be funded up to a maximum of **€25,000** each, along with micro-grants starting from **€10,000**.

VI.5. What should be known about the different phases of the Fund?

The implementation of the Election Civic Tech Fund is structured into four distinct phases, spread over a maximum of ten (10) months.

The timeline for Fund management and technical support is as follows:

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Phase	Month	Activities
Phase 1	June-August 2025	Launch Selection Contracting Initial training
Phase 2	Septembre 2025 – April 2026	Implementation Capacity building Support
Phase 3	August-Septembre 2026	Final evaluation Capitalisation
Phase 4	Octobre 2026	Capitalisation White paper

VII. How to respond to the call for proposals?

VII.1. Where to find the call for proposals?

L'appel à projets sera lancé sur le site institutionnel de [AfricTivistes](#), les sites de [AHEAD Africa](#) et [Digitalise Youth](#) et diffusé à travers les réseaux de AfricTivistes et des partenaires des consortiums respectifs.

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The call for proposals will be published on this platform <https://electioncivictechfund.africtivistes.com/en>, the official website of [AfricTivistes](#), as well as on the websites of [AHEAD Africa](#) and [Digitalise Youth](#). It will also be circulated through the networks of AfricTivistes and the respective consortium partners.

VII.2. In which languages can proposals be submitted?

Applications may be submitted in **French** or **English** to ensure inclusive participation from the target countries.

VII.3. How to submit an application?

- Applicants must, via the dedicated platform <https://electioncivictechfund.africtivistes.com/en> :
 - Complete the detailed application form (*only applications submitted via the form will be considered*)
 - Attach the required administrative documents (see Section VII.4 and the Terms of Reference)
 - Submit a detailed project description (maximum 12 pages) (see the [provided template](#))
 - Submit a detailed budget using the provided template (see budget model)

VII.4. What documents are required?

- An official registration document for the organisation, movement or association in one of the 14 priority countries
- An official registration document for the lead organisation in case of a consortium application
- CVs of two (2) to three (3) key team members

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- A detailed project description (maximum five pages) using the provided template, including:
 - Theory of change
 - Implementation plan over a maximum of ten months
 - Detailed budget using the model included in the annexes

VII.5. What is the timeline for this call for proposals?

- Call launch: **10 June 2025**
- Submission deadline: **10 July 2025**
- Evaluation of applications: **11–17 July 2025**
- Announcement of results: **18 July 2025**

VIII. What results does the Fund aim to achieve?

- More than six electoral civic tech initiatives funded
- A dedicated support fund is made available to encourage the emergence of civic tech and the participation of youth and women
- The use of civic technologies in electoral processes is strengthened
- A network for collaboration and the exchange of best practices among beneficiaries is established

XI. ANNEXES

- [Application Project description template](#)
- [Budget template](#)
- [Terms of reference – Call for proposals: Election Civic Tech Fund](#)

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- Dedicated platform link: <https://electioncivictechfund.africtivistes.com/en>

Contacts

For any further information, please write to info@africtivistes.org

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